CANDIDATE WRITE-UP

Karma R. · Backend engineer, payments platform

CLIENT	INTERVIEWED BY	INTERVIEW
Example Co., Bengaluru	Ex-Staff Engineer, 11 years	42 minutes, recorded with consent
SCORECARD	**THIS BATCH**	**RANK**
Agreed with the hiring manager	14 interviewed, 3 sent	2 of the 3 sent

SELECT

40 / 50

Strong on the parts of this job that hurt when they go wrong. He rebuilt a caching layer during a 10x traffic spike and could give the numbers before and after. Thinner on documentation: his team relied on him to explain the system. Worth a final round on how he hands over.



The scorecard

SKILL	SCORE	THE EVIDENCE, WITH THE MOMENT IN THE RECORDING
Core depth	4.5	Explained cache invalidation for ledger reads without being asked, and why balances are never cached for decisions. 08:40
Systems design	4	Sketched a read path that survives a regional failover. Missed idempotency on retries until prompted once. 17:15
Delivery speed	4	Shipped the caching change in two weeks behind a flag, rolled back once, then forward. 22:05
Controls and risk	3.5	Clear on what sits inside PCI scope. Vaguer on audit logging. 26:30
Documentation	3	Runbooks existed, but the team called him at 2am anyway. He said so himself. 31:10
Stakeholder handling	4.5	Pushed back on a launch date with data and kept the launch. 36:45
Total	**40 / 50**	**Clears your bar of 34 by 6.**

Three answers, in his words

08:40 · Why not cache everything?

“Because the ledger can’t be wrong for even a second. We cached balances for display and never for decisions. Reads dropped about seventy percent and nobody saw a wrong number.”

What this tells you
He separates display paths from decision paths. That is the core of this role.

17:15 · The payment service times out. What happens on retry?

“It retries the payment, so that’s a double charge. You’d need an idempotency key on the request. I should have said that first.”

What this tells you
He got there with one prompt and owned the miss. Test it again on a fresh problem.

31:10 · Who else could run that system?

“Honestly, the runbook was in my head. Two people could restart it. Nobody else could change it.”

What this tells you
Honest, and the main risk for a team of eight.

Open questions for your final round

01 Ask him to write the handover for a system he owns. Read it before you meet him.

02 Give him a fresh retry problem. Check that idempotency comes up without a prompt.

03 He said he wants to manage and to stay hands-on. Ask which, in eighteen months.

What we couldn’t test

01 Leading more than two people.

02 On-call culture in a team of fifty or more engineers.

The practical details

Notice	30 days, can do 15
Current CTC	₹31 lakh per annum
Expected	₹38 lakh per annum
Location	Bengaluru, onsite is fine
Other offers	One, at final round

How this was made. A senior interviewer who has done the job ran a 42-minute interview, with the candidate’s consent to record it. They scored each skill against the scorecard agreed with your hiring manager, weighted as agreed. A model drafted the evidence notes from the transcript, and the interviewer checked every one. The model doesn’t decide, and isn’t allowed to reject anyone. The recording and full transcript come with every write-up.